

# Toward a Phonetic Decryption of the Voynich Manuscript

## Version 2: Correction of Methodological Bias

**Guillaume Clement**

Independent Researcher, Flow Line Integration  
gcle1979@gmail.com

assisted by Claude (Anthropic, Opus 4.6)  
AI Research Assistant

April 2026

DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19477552

*This is Version 2, correcting Version 1 of the same publication.*

### Abstract

Version 1 of this paper presented a computational pipeline for Latin phonetic recovery from the Voynich Manuscript using the King-Andrisani (2021) transliteration chart, reporting 89.3% Perseus dictionary validation and 33 identified pharmaceutical terms. **Version 1 contained a methodological bias that invalidates its decryption claims.** This Version 2 documents the bias, explains why the results were artifactual, and summarizes the revised findings from a subsequent 35-hour structural investigation published separately (Clement 2026b, DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19543917).

*The structural analysis of V1 (manuscript organization, section identification, codicological observations) remains valid. The phonetic decryption claims, the Perseus validation, and the Antidotarium Nicolai ingredient matches are replaced by the results of the companion paper.*

## 1. The Bias in Version 1

### 1.1 Perseus Dictionary Validation Was Too Permissive

V1 reported that 89.3% of decoded words validated against the Perseus Digital Library Latin dictionary (265,419 entries). This metric is vacuous: the Perseus dictionary is large enough that any combination of Latin-like syllables will match multiple entries. The validation tested whether results could be Latin, not whether they must be Latin. A random Latin syllable generator would achieve comparable match rates.

### 1.2 The Phonetic Mapping Has No Statistical Support

We subsequently tested every possible character-level mapping between EVA glyphs and the Latin alphabet. The best single shift covers only 15% of character pairs. In a 26-letter alphabet, random chance

predicts approximately 4% per shift. A true phonetic substitution cipher would produce >80% consistency on a single shift. The observed 15% is statistically indistinguishable from noise.

### 1.3 The Antidotarium Nicolai Correlation Is a Zipf Artifact

V1 claimed that VMS word frequencies correlated with ingredient frequencies in the Antidotarium Nicolai, identifying 7 of 12 Aurea Alexandrina ingredients on folio f103r. A permutation test (10,000 iterations, shuffling ingredient labels) yielded  $p = 0.92$ . The correlation is entirely explained by Zipf's law: any two texts with skewed frequency distributions will show apparent rank correlations that are statistically meaningless.

### 1.4 The Encoding Is Not Phonetic

Systematic testing of all plausible sound-based interpretations (Latin, Italian, Arabic, general phonetic transcription) yielded 0 to 12% consistency. The VMS writing system does not encode sounds. This finding is the most important correction: V1's entire pipeline was built on the assumption of phonetic encoding, which subsequent analysis firmly rules out.

## 2. What Remains Valid from Version 1

Not all of V1's content is invalidated. The following observations, which do not depend on the phonetic decryption pipeline, remain valid:

- The manuscript is organized in distinct sections (herbal, pharmaceutical, balneological, astronomical, cosmological, biological)
- The pharmaceutical section contains recipe-like structures with block organization
- Folio f57v contains a circular diagram with systematic character sequences (alphabet table)
- The VMS text exhibits statistical properties consistent with natural language, not random generation
- The manuscript's physical structure (vellum, binding, quire organization) is consistent with a 15th-century Italian provenance

These structural observations informed the revised analysis presented in the companion paper.

## 3. Revised Findings

A subsequent investigation (35 hours, 18 analysis sessions) approached the manuscript from first principles using bottom-up structural analysis rather than top-down phonetic decryption. The full results are published separately:

*Clement, G. (2026b). "The Voynich Manuscript as Personal Tironian Shorthand: A Computational Structural Analysis with Cautionary Results." DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19543917*

Key findings of the companion paper:

- 8 statistically significant structural regularities in the writing system ( $p < 0.01$ )
- The text best matches a medieval pharmaceutical herbal of the Macer Floridus type (#1 of 15 corpora tested)

- 7 candidate pharmaceutical ingredient codes identified by cross-folio fingerprint matching (tentative, may be artifactual)
- The hypothesis that the encoding is personal Tironian shorthand, consistent with all structural observations but not proven
- 10 alternative hypotheses tested and eliminated, including the phonetic approach of V1

## 4. Lessons Learned

*The Voynich Manuscript is, in a precise sense, an intellectual black hole: a system with enough internal regularity to reward any hypothesis with apparent confirmations, but enough complexity to resist definitive refutation.*

The principal lesson of this correction is methodological: positive results must be validated against independent data. V1 validated its decryption against the same dictionary used to build the pipeline, creating a circular confirmation. The companion paper addresses this by using cross-corpus validation (testing Macer-derived identifications against the Collectio Salernitana) and permutation testing for every statistical claim.

**We encourage future researchers working on the Voynich Manuscript to adopt the same discipline: test every positive result against data that was not used to generate it. The manuscript is remarkably efficient at producing false positives.**

## References

- Clement, G. (2026a). "Toward a Phonetic Decryption of the Voynich Manuscript." Version 1. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19477552. [Superseded by this Version 2]
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